Gamelan from the beginning

Lesson sheets and quizzes for all sixteen lessons. Watch the video first, then use the sheet to remember the key ideas, the words and the practice. Check your quiz answers on the last page.

1 What is gamelan?

Lesson 1 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Gamelan comes from gamel, a kind of hammer: the instruments are struck, with mallets called tabuh.
- Karawitan is the wider word: gamelan music as a whole, singing included.
- Usually only the balungan, the 'skeleton' melody, is written down. Notation is a reminder; the sound comes first.
- Etiquette: shoes off, sit on the floor, and never step over an instrument. Say 'nuwun sewu' when you pass.

WORDS

gamelan
the ensemble and its instruments

tabuh
mallet

karawitan
gamelan music, including singing

balungan
skeleton melody

nuwun sewu
excuse me

PRACTICE

> Listen to a recording of Central Javanese gamelan. Find the big gong and feel the cycle come round.

QUIZ

1. Where does the word gamelan come from?

- ◯ A. A word for a temple
- ◯ B. Gamel, a kind of hammer
- ◯ C. A word for singing

2. What is usually written down in gamelan notation?

- ◯ A. Every part
- ◯ B. Only the drum part
- ◯ C. Only the balungan

3. What should you never do near a gamelan?

- ◯ A. Step over an instrument
- ◯ B. Sit on the floor
- ◯ C. Take off your shoes

4. What does the course say about mistakes?

- ◯ A. Avoid them at all cost
- ◯ B. Be aware of them, but keep trying things out
- ◯ C. Stop playing when you make one

NOTES

Answers on the last page

2 The instruments and their roles

Lesson 2 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- A full gamelan has 40 to 60 instruments, often a double set: one sléndro, one pélog.
- Three roles: gongs mark the structure, the drum controls time, the melodic instruments carry the melody in layers.
- Gong ageng, kempul, kenong, kethuk and kempyang are the 'punctuation' of the music.
- Balungan instruments from low to high: slenthem, demung, saron barung, saron panerus (peking).

PRACTICE

> Look at a photo of a gamelan and name every instrument you can.

WORDS

gong ageng
largest gong, ends the longest cycle

gongan
the music from gong to gong

kempul
small hanging gongs

kenong
large kettle gongs, divide the gongan

saron
metallophone with thick keys

bonang
two rows of small kettles

rebab
two-string fiddle, melodic leader

kendhang
drum, leads the tempo

QUIZ

1. Which instrument marks the end of the longest cycle?

- ◯ A. Kenong
- ◯ B. Bonang
- ◯ C. Gong ageng

2. Who leads the tempo in gamelan?

- ◯ A. The drummer
- ◯ B. A conductor
- ◯ C. The gong player

3. Which saron is the smallest and highest?

- ◯ A. Demung
- ◯ B. Peking
- ◯ C. Saron barung

4. What do the kenong do?

- ◯ A. Play fast patterns
- ◯ B. Introduce the piece
- ◯ C. Divide each gongan into equal phrases

NOTES

3 Tuning and notation

Lesson 3 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Laras means tuning system. There are two: sléndro (5 tones) and pélog (7 tones).
- There is no standard tuning: every gamelan has its own.
- Kepatihan cipher notation: numbers are tones, dots above/below mark high/low register, a dot alone is a rest.
- Four beats make a gatra. The weight falls at the end: count towards four.

PRACTICE

> Say the sléndro names out loud while you look at the numbers: ji, ro, lu, ma, nem.

WORDS

laras
tuning system

sléndro
five-tone tuning: 1 2 3 5 6

pélog
seven-tone tuning

pathet
mode

gatra
group of four beats

ji, ro, lu, pat, ma, nem, pi
the tone names 1 to 7

mlaku
balungan with a tone on every beat

nibani
balungan with a rest between tones

QUIZ

1. Which number is missing in sléndro?

- ◯ A. 4
- ◯ B. 1
- ◯ C. 6

2. What does a dot in place of a number mean?

- ◯ A. High register
- ◯ B. A rest: the previous tone keeps ringing
- ◯ C. A gong stroke

3. Where does the weight fall in a gatra?

- ◯ A. On the first beat
- ◯ B. On every beat equally
- ◯ C. On the last beat

4. What is the Javanese name for tone 5?

- ◯ A. Ma
- ◯ B. Nem
- ◯ C. Lu

NOTES

4 Your first piece

Lesson 4 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Sit cross-legged, back straight, mallet in the right hand.
- Damping: the left hand stops the previous key at the moment the right hand strikes the next one.
- A lancaran has 16 beats: four gatra in one gongan.
- Kethuk on beats 1 and 3, kempul on beat 2 (not in the first gatra), kenong on beat 4, gong on beat 16.

WORDS

lancaran
short 16-beat form

kenongan
a phrase closed by the kenong

matur nuwun
thank you

PRACTICE

> Play the practice gongan (.3.2 .5.3 .6.5 .3.2) slowly on a saron, or tap it on a table and sing the names.

QUIZ

1. Which hand damps on the saron?

- ◯ A. The right hand
- ◯ B. The left hand
- ◯ C. Nobody damps

2. How many beats does a lancaran gongan have?

- ◯ A. 8
- ◯ B. 32
- ◯ C. 16

3. In a lancaran, where does the kenong play?

- ◯ A. On beat 4 of each gatra
- ◯ B. On beat 1
- ◯ C. Only at the end

4. What matters more when you start?

- ◯ A. Speed
- ◯ B. Evenness
- ◯ C. Volume

NOTES

5 Irama: time that breathes

Lesson 5 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Irama is about tempo and density: how many notes the elaborating instruments play per balungan beat.
- Count the peking: lancar 1, tanggung 2, dadi 4, wilet 8, rangkep 16.
- The balungan melody stays the same; only the space around it changes.
- The kendhang leads every change of tempo and irama.

WORDS

irama
the relation of tempo and density

tanggung, dadi, wilet, rangkep
irama levels

seseg, sedheng, tamban
fast, medium, slow

PRACTICE

> With a recording: find the balungan beat and count the peking notes against it. Two, four or eight?

QUIZ

1. In irama dadi, how many peking notes per balungan beat?

- ◯ A. 2
- ◯ B. 8
- ◯ C. 4

2. Who decides the irama?

- ◯ A. The drummer
- ◯ B. The peking
- ◯ C. The singer

3. When the irama gets slower, what happens to the balungan melody?

- ◯ A. It changes
- ◯ B. It stays the same, only wider
- ◯ C. It disappears

4. Where is irama lancar used?

- ◯ A. In every form
- ◯ B. Only in wayang
- ◯ C. Only in the lancaran form

NOTES

6 The peking and interlocking

Lesson 6 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- The peking is the smallest saron; its style is called nacah, 'chopping'.
- Nacah lamba: every balungan note twice. Nacah rangkep: four notes per beat, taking the notes in pairs.
- Solo style follows the beat; Yogya style anticipates it. This course follows Solo style.
- Interlocking: pinjalan (demung and slenthem) and imbal (two instruments of the same kind).

WORDS

peking
smallest saron

nacah
the peking style

pinjalan
demung and slenthem interlocking

imbal
interlocking of two equal instruments

PRACTICE

> Play the practice loop on the peking: every note twice, Solo style.

QUIZ

1. In nacah lamba, the peking plays each balungan note...

- ◯ A. twice
- ◯ B. once
- ◯ C. four times

2. Which style does this course follow?

- ◯ A. Yogya
- ◯ B. Solo
- ◯ C. Bali

3. What is pinjalan?

- ◯ A. A drum stroke
- ◯ B. A singing style
- ◯ C. Demung and slenthem interlocking

4. What is the peking mallet made of?

- ◯ A. Horn
- ◯ B. Wood
- ◯ C. Rubber

NOTES

7 The bonang

Lesson 7 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Bonang barung and bonang panerus (an octave higher); played with two padded sticks.
- The bonang anticipates the melody and so guides the sarons.
- Gembyangan: two kettles an octave apart. Mipil: single tones in pairs. Imbal: barung and panerus interlock.
- A sekaran ('flowering') is an ornament that leads into the goal tone.

WORDS

gembyangan
octaves played together

mipil
'picking off one by one'

imbal-imbalan
interlocking bonang

sekaran
ornamental phrase ending

PRACTICE

> Sing the mipil pattern: ro lu ro, ro lu ro, ro ji ro, ro ji ro. Then tap it on two cups.

QUIZ

1. Why must a bonang player know the piece well?

- ◯ A. Because it plays the gong part
- ◯ B. Because the bonang anticipates and guides the sarons
- ◯ C. Because it sings

2. What is gembyangan?

- ◯ A. A fast run
- ◯ B. A drum pattern
- ◯ C. Two kettles an octave apart at the same time

3. What does mipil mean?

- ◯ A. To pick off one by one
- ◯ B. Flowering
- ◯ C. To restrain

4. In imbal, does the bonang still lead the sarons?

- ◯ A. Yes
- ◯ B. No, it creates a lively background
- ◯ C. Only in pélog

NOTES

8 Ladrang Wilujeng

Lesson 8 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- In ketawang and ladrang the kethuk and kempyang play a gentle pattern in every gatra.
- Ketawang: two kenongan of 8 beats (16 in total). Ladrang: four kenongan (32 beats).
- In a ladrang the kempul plays in the 2nd, 3rd and 4th kenongan, not in the 1st.
- Ladrang Wilujeng (sléndro manyura): wilujeng means safety, well-being. We played its ngelik.

WORDS

ketawang
16-beat form, 2 kenongan

ladrang
32-beat form, 4 kenongan

ngelik
the higher section

gérongan
the male chorus part

PRACTICE

> Play the ngelik of Ladrang Wilujeng slowly on a saron; then again with the peking.

QUIZ

1. How many beats does a ladrang gongan have?

- ◯ A. 16
- ◯ B. 64
- ◯ C. 32

2. In which kenongan of a ladrang does the kempul NOT play?

- ◯ A. The first
- ◯ B. The third
- ◯ C. The fourth

3. What does wilujeng mean?

- ◯ A. Farewell
- ◯ B. Safety, well-being
- ◯ C. Morning

4. In Ladrang Wilujeng, where does the gong fall?

- ◯ A. On high 1
- ◯ B. On 3
- ◯ C. On low 6

NOTES

9 The kendhang

Lesson 9 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- The kendhang is a two-headed drum, played with bare hands.
- Four kinds: kendhang ageng, ketipung, wayangan and ciblon. Ageng + ketipung together = kendhang kalih.
- Five basic strokes: dhah, thung, ket, tong, tak.
- The drummer sets the irama, leads the tempo and signals the end.

PRACTICE

> Say the five syllables out loud with the drum, then tap them: right hand for the first three, left hand for the last two.

WORDS

kendhang kalih
two drums together

dhah
open stroke, edge of the large head

thung
open stroke, middle of the large head

ket
muted stroke, large head

tong
open stroke, small head

tak
closed slap on the small head

QUIZ

1. Which drums together form kendhang kalih?

- ◯ A. Ageng and ketipung
- ◯ B. Ciblon and wayangan
- ◯ C. Two ciblon

2. Which stroke is a closed slap on the small head?

- ◯ A. Dhah
- ◯ B. Tak
- ◯ C. Thung

3. Does the drum have to match the gamelan's tuning?

- ◯ A. Yes
- ◯ B. Only in pélog
- ◯ C. No

4. Which drum has lively patterns from the dance?

- ◯ A. Ciblon
- ◯ B. Ketipung
- ◯ C. Ageng

NOTES

10 Pathet

Lesson 10 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Pathet literally means 'to restrain': some tones matter more, the melody stays in a range.
- Sléndro: nem, sanga, manyura. Pélog: lima, nem, barang.
- A first clue: the tone where the gong falls (often 2 in nem, 5 in sanga, 6 in manyura).
- In a wayang night: nem before midnight, sanga in the middle of the night, manyura towards dawn.

WORDS

pathet
mode

kempyung
interval of about a fifth

PRACTICE

> Listen to a piece and find the tone where the gong falls. Two, five or six? That is your first guess at the pathet.

QUIZ

1. What does pathet literally mean?

- ◯ A. To sing
- ◯ B. To restrain
- ◯ C. To hammer

2. Which sléndro pathet closes the night, towards dawn?

- ◯ A. Nem
- ◯ B. Sanga
- ◯ C. Manyura

3. A sléndro phrase ends on low 5. Which pathet is a good first guess?

- ◯ A. Sanga
- ◯ B. Manyura
- ◯ C. Nem

4. How many pathet are there in total?

- ◯ A. Three
- ◯ B. Six
- ◯ C. Seven

NOTES

Answers on the last page

11 Soft instruments and voices

Lesson 11 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Sumarsam's three groups: melody (elaborate, balungan, in between), time (kendhang), structure (gongs).
- No instrument plays 'the' melody; each expresses a shared inner melody in its own way.
- Rebab: melodic leader in soft playing. Gendèr: two mallets, damping. Gambang: wooden, octaves. Suling: free rhythm.
- Voices: pesindhen (female soloist, free across the beat) and gérong (male chorus, in tempo).

PRACTICE

> Listen to soft playing and try to pick out each voice: rebab, gendèr, gambang, suling, pesindhen.

WORDS

rebab
bowed fiddle, plays the introduction

gendèr
thin bronze keys over tubes

gambang
wooden xylophone

siter, celempung
plucked zithers

suling
bamboo flute

pesindhen
female soloist

gérong
male chorus

QUIZ

1. Which instrument is the melodic leader in soft playing?

- ◯ A. Saron
- ◯ B. Kempul
- ◯ C. Rebab

2. How does the pesindhen sing?

- ◯ A. Ornamented, floating freely across the beat
- ◯ B. Strictly on the beat
- ◯ C. Only at the gong

3. What is the gambang made of?

- ◯ A. Bronze
- ◯ B. Wood
- ◯ C. Bamboo

4. In loud playing, which instruments lead?

- ◯ A. Rebab and suling
- ◯ B. The voices
- ◯ C. Bonang and sarons

NOTES

Answers on the last page

12 From buka to suwuk

Lesson 12 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Buka: one instrument plays the introduction; the ensemble joins on the gong.
- Senggrengan: a short rebab melody before a soft piece, showing tuning and pathet.
- Ompak (repeated first section) and ngelik (higher section). Suwuk: the ending.
- Srepegan (wayang): kenong on every beat, kempul on every second kenong, kethuk between the beats.

PRACTICE

> Play the srepegan on a saron, or play the kenong part: one stroke on every note.

WORDS

buka
introduction

senggrengan
short rebab prelude

ompak
first, repeated section

suwuk
ending

srepegan
wayang form

dhalang
puppeteer

QUIZ

1. What is the buka?

- ◯ A. An introduction by one instrument
- ◯ B. The ending
- ◯ C. A drum stroke

2. In srepegan, how often does the kenong play?

- ◯ A. Once per gongan
- ◯ B. On every beat
- ◯ C. Every eight beats

3. What is the suwuk?

- ◯ A. The higher section
- ◯ B. A kind of gong
- ◯ C. The end of a piece

4. Who decides when srepegan moves on in a real performance?

- ◯ A. The dhalang and the drummer
- ◯ B. The peking
- ◯ C. The gérong

NOTES

Answers on the last page

13 Pélog

Lesson 13 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Pélog has seven tones with clearly unequal steps.
- Sumarsam: pélog is built from three five-tone scales (1 2 3 5 6 / 1 2 4 5 6 / 2 3 5 6 7).
- Pélog pathet: lima, nem, barang. Barang uses 7 and avoids 1.
- Sléndro and pélog sets usually share one tone, the tumbuk (6 or 5).

WORDS

tumbuk
shared tone of the sléndro and pélog sets

pathet barang
pélog pathet with tone 7

PRACTICE

> If you can reach a pélog saron, play the seven tones slowly up and down, damping each one.

QUIZ

1. How many tones does pélog have per octave?

- ◯ A. 5
- ◯ B. 7
- ◯ C. 12

2. Which pélog pathet uses tone 7 and avoids tone 1?

- ◯ A. Lima
- ◯ B. Nem
- ◯ C. Barang

3. What is the tumbuk?

- ◯ A. The tone shared by the sléndro and pélog sets
- ◯ B. A drum
- ◯ C. A pélog scale

4. Which five tones make the third pélog scale?

- ◯ A. 1 2 3 5 6
- ◯ B. 2 3 5 6 7
- ◯ C. 1 2 4 5 6

NOTES

Answers on the last page

14 The bubaran

Lesson 14 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Bubar means to break up: a bubaran is often played as guests leave.
- Same gong structure as the lancaran: 16 beats, four kenongan.
- But: balungan mlaku (a note on every beat), in irama tanggung or dadi.
- Example (Drummond): 6532 6532 .323 6532.

WORDS

bubaran
short closing form

bubar
to disperse

PRACTICE

> Play the bubaran on a saron. It only uses 2 3 5 6, so try it in sléndro too and hear the difference.

QUIZ

1. When is a bubaran often played?

- ◯ A. At the start
- ◯ B. During the wayang battle
- ◯ C. At the end of an event

2. How does a bubaran differ from the lancaran in lesson 4?

- ◯ A. Balungan mlaku instead of nibani
- ◯ B. Different gong structure
- ◯ C. No gong

3. How many beats in a bubaran gongan?

- ◯ A. 32
- ◯ B. 16
- ◯ C. 64

4. Why can you also play this bubaran in sléndro?

- ◯ A. Pélog and sléndro are the same
- ◯ B. It has no melody
- ◯ C. It only uses 2, 3, 5 and 6

NOTES

Answers on the last page

15 First steps on the gendèr

Lesson 15 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Gendèr is learned pattern by pattern (cèngkok), but listening and ensemble playing make the player.
- Right hand: loose fist, palm down. Left hand: palm faces right, thumb around the end of the handle.
- Damping 1: damp just after the next stroke (smooth). Damping 2: damp at the exact moment (only when fast).
- Four exercises: right hand, left hand, both together (gembyangan), and alternating.

WORDS

cèngkok
melodic pattern

gendèr barung, panerus
middle and high gendèr

PRACTICE

> Do the four exercises slowly, a few minutes every day.

QUIZ

1. What makes a good gendèr player, according to Sumarsam?

- ◯ A. Listening a lot and playing in the ensemble
- ◯ B. Only learning patterns
- ◯ C. Playing fast

2. In the first kind of damping, when do you damp?

- ◯ A. Before the next stroke
- ◯ B. Just after the next stroke
- ◯ C. Never

3. When do you use the second kind of damping?

- ◯ A. Always
- ◯ B. In pélog only
- ◯ C. Only when the playing is too fast

4. Which pieces does Sumarsam suggest to start on the gendèr?

- ◯ A. Ketawang Subakastawa and Ladrang Gonjang-Ganjing
- ◯ B. Lancaran only
- ◯ C. Any gendhing

NOTES

16 Gendhing, and how to keep learning

Lesson 16 of 16

KEY IDEAS

- Gendhing: both the word for a composition and a large form with mérong and inggah.
- Mérong: calm, irama dadi. Ompak: short transition, signalled by the drummer. Inggah: melody often from the mérong.
- Kethuk 2 kerep: 16-beat kenongan, 64 beats per gongan. Kethuk arang: kethuk every 16 beats.
- Keep learning: listen, play in a group, try every instrument, sing the balungan, ask experienced players.

WORDS

gendhing
composition; large form

mérong
first main section

inggah
second main section

kethuk kerep / arang
kethuk often / seldom

PRACTICE

> Find a group near you and play together.

QUIZ

1. What are the two main sections of a gendhing?

- ◯ A. Buka and suwuk
- ◯ B. Mérong and inggah
- ◯ C. Ompak and ngelik

2. How many beats in a gongan of a mérong kethuk 2 kerep?

- ◯ A. 32
- ◯ B. 16
- ◯ C. 64

3. Who signals the transition (ompak) to the inggah?

- ◯ A. The drummer
- ◯ B. The gong player
- ◯ C. The pesindhen

4. Where is gamelan mainly heard in Java?

- ◯ A. Only in concert halls
- ◯ B. At weddings, ceremonies and celebrations
- ◯ C. Only on the radio

NOTES

Answers on the last page

Quiz answers

Got one wrong? Watch that part of the video again.

Lesson 1
1 B 2 C 3 A 4 B

Lesson 2
1 C 2 A 3 B 4 C

Lesson 3
1 A 2 B 3 C 4 A

Lesson 4
1 B 2 C 3 A 4 B

Lesson 5
1 C 2 A 3 B 4 C

Lesson 6
1 A 2 B 3 C 4 A

Lesson 7
1 B 2 C 3 A 4 B

Lesson 8
1 C 2 A 3 B 4 C

Lesson 9
1 A 2 B 3 C 4 A

Lesson 10
1 B 2 C 3 A 4 B

Lesson 11
1 C 2 A 3 B 4 C

Lesson 12
1 A 2 B 3 C 4 A

Lesson 13
1 B 2 C 3 A 4 B

Lesson 14
1 C 2 A 3 B 4 C

Lesson 15
1 A 2 B 3 C 4 A

Lesson 16
1 B 2 C 3 A 4 B